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Democracy Dies in Darkness

TUESDAY, OCTOBER 14, 2025 • \$4

Retirement wave taxes federal agencies

Government feels the strain as understaffing exacerbates shutdown

BY MERYL KORNFELD
AND HANNAH NATANSON

A historic wave of retirements and other departures has swept through the federal workforce in recent months, putting enormous strain on agencies as they cope with a new government shutdown and administration layoffs. This mass exodus — unprecedented in its scale — includes 154,000 federal employees who accepted buyout offers and were largely removed from the payroll as of the end of last month. Some of those are among nearly 105,000 employees who took regular retirement during the fiscal year that ended in September, an 18 percent surge from the previous year.

Tens of thousands of the cases are still awaiting processing, creating a crisis for already understaffed human resources offices across the government and the Office of Personnel Management.

With a significantly reduced workforce of its own, OPM has a growing backlog and worsening wait times, raising alarms about the government's ability to smoothly handle this unprecedented personnel shift, according to documents and interviews with HR representatives and departed federal workers.

Complicating the efforts, the government shutdown that began on Oct. 1 has furloughed

SEE RETIREMENT ON A5

Fortunes of two key sectors are diverging

AI is ascendant in the U.S., but manufacturing only continues to slide

BY AARON GREGG
AND FEDERICA COCCO

A gulf is opening up in the heart of American business as two industries championed as central to the country's future — manufacturing and artificial intelligence — appear to be heading in different directions.

Both AI and manufacturing have been in the spotlight in Washington through successive administrations. President Donald Trump this year said he would do “whatever it takes to lead the world in artificial intelligence,” while he has championed stemming a decades-long slide in American manufacturing as a top goal.

But while AI is flourishing this year, manufacturing is entering an ever deeper slump.

“You have the software and services world accelerating, and becoming almost a monomania for the culture, at the same time that manufacturing remains flat or worse,” said Mark Muro, a

SEE MANUFACTURING ON A19

Hamas returns all 20 living hostages to Israel

Trump: ‘This long and difficult war has now ended’

Almost 2,000 Palestinians also released in deal

A transformational, but tenuous, peace

BY ISAAC ARNSDORF, MICHAEL BIRNBAUM
AND CLAIRE PARKER



HEIDI LEVINE/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Thousands celebrate the release of Israeli hostages at a plaza known as “Hostages Square” in Tel Aviv.



MENAHEM KAHANA/AFP/GETTY IMAGES

Released Israeli hostage Evyatar David blows kisses at Beilinson Hospital in Petah Tikva, Israel.



MAHMOUD ISSA/REUTERS

A man greets a freed Palestinian prisoner released by Israel as part of a hostages-for-prisoners swap.

President Donald Trump on Monday marked the end of Israel's devastating two-year war in Gaza and the release of the remaining Israeli hostages with a call for lasting peace that would reshape the entire Middle East and could become a defining feature of his place in history.

But the tenuousness of the ceasefire and the intractability of the underlying disputes were embedded in his two separate stops.

First, in Jerusalem, he welcomed the hostages home, met with their families and received acclaim and ovations from Israeli leaders, whom he urged to declare victory and stop fighting. Next, he headed to the Egyptian resort town of Sharm el-Sheikh to visit Arab and other world leaders who supported the ceasefire and Trump's 20-step plan for a permanent settlement.

Though billed as a “peace summit,” the Egypt meeting notably lacked either side of the fighting. Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu declined Trump's last-minute invitation, saying that travel would conflict with a Jewish holiday, after at least one Arab leader objected. Hamas was never included, and the organization has refused to disarm, as Trump's plan would require.

Still, Trump portrayed Mon-

day's steps as the prelude to a broader reshaping of the region, hoping to build on his first term's Abraham Accords that normalized Israel's relations with the United Arab Emirates, Bahrain, Morocco and Sudan. His overture extended even to Iran, whose nuclear sites the U.S. bombed in June.

“This long and difficult war has now ended. You know, some people say 3,000 years, some people say 500 years. Whatever it is, it's the granddaddy of them all,” he said in a speech to Israel's parliament. “This is the historic dawn of a new Middle East.”

The immediate effect Monday was to return all 20 living hostages to Israel; release about 1,700 Palestinian detainees and 250 serving life sentences in Israeli prisons; and facilitate the resumption of humanitarian aid to Gaza, where residents desperately need food, medicine and shelter. Hamas said Monday it would release the bodies of four of the 28 dead hostages it held, after warning that it would not be able to recover all the remains in time for the 72-hour deadline stipulated by the deal. The agreement also builds in extra time for a group of regional countries, including Turkey, to help to locate the remains.

SEE ISRAEL ON A16

After a grueling two years, families reunite and jubilation resounds

BY LIOR SOROKA,
HEIDI LEVINE
AND LOUISA LOVELUCK

TEL AVIV — The 20 surviving Israeli hostages held by Hamas in Gaza regained their freedom Monday, more than two years after they were kidnapped, amid emotional scenes and jubilation from crowds gathered to welcome them home.

The first captives were handed over at about 8:30 a.m. local time to the International Committee of the Red Cross, which facilitated their transfer to Israel, where their families awaited them and thousands of supporters cheered their passage.

The men had been among 250 people seized by Hamas militants from southern Israel on Oct. 7, 2023, during an attack that killed some 1,200 people. Israel's retaliatory response in Gaza has killed more than 67,000 people over two years of war, according to local health authorities, who don't distinguish between civilians and combatants but say the majority are women and children.

Video footage shared by families of the hostages on Monday showed that some of them had been given phones shortly before their release, allowing them to

make direct contact with their loved ones for the first time in more than two years. Hours later, photographs distributed by the Israeli military showed the men — many pale and gaunt — being received by the army at the Re'im military base, and then brought to hospitals and into the embrace of their loved ones.

Relatives of the former hostages, interviewed Sunday, had described the moment as surreal, overwhelming and hard to grasp. The father of 48-year-old hostage Omri Miran, Dani, said Sunday that he felt as though he were “in the clouds.”

Miran, a Hungarian Israeli gardener and massage therapist, hid in a safe room with his wife and two young daughters as the militant attack on their home in Kibbutz Nahal Oz unfolded. He was taken hostage after opening the door to a young neighbor who had told them: “Please open the door. Otherwise they'll shoot me, and they'll shoot you.”

SEE HOSTAGES ON A16

Joyful scenes span borders

Images of homecomings in Israel, Gaza and the West Bank. A14

In search of peace

Trump says the Gaza deal probably won't send him to heaven. A15

Death of Md. boy illustrates a danger for children with autism

BY JASMINE GOLDEN

Miles McMahon ran up and squeezed between his parents, dancing as Disney tunes filled the kitchen of their Southern Maryland home. He puffed up his cheeks with air, bursting with laughter as his parents popped them that Sunday morning in October 2024.

They tickled and hugged and kissed Miles. They spun him

around the room. A breeze blew through an open window, cooling the space in the autumn heat. As the morning wound down and the plan turned to showers and a walk, the family went upstairs to get ready.

They didn't expect the doorbell.

Or how it would be the sound that bisected their lives. Before. And after.

Dominique McMahon, a 32-

year-old wife and mother of two, rushed to get dressed. The ringing was relentless.

“Where's Miles?” she remembers asking aloud.

The question had grown to consume their days at home and those of his teachers at school in Charles County. Miles, a kindergarten, had autism and wasn't yet speaking. He had been a wanderer since he could walk.

SEE AUTISM ON A8



DOMINIQUE MCCMAHON

The death of Miles McMahon, 5, who was prone to running away, prompted a new law in Maryland.

IN THE NEWS

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